SURFDESK

Surfdesk: why it matters and how to answer push-back

Internal sales brief, not for customers. Updated November 12, 2026.

1. The one-sentence difference

> **Clarity is where an agency reports to the government. Surfdesk is where staff do the work.**

The analogy that lands: **Clarity is the agency's tax return; Surfdesk is its planner.** Everyone has to file taxes in the official format. Nobody runs their day out of their tax software.

Clarity (an HMIS, or Homeless Management Information System) exists to collect the exact data HUD requires and produce federal reports. It's built for *compliance*. Surfdesk is built for the *daily job*: remembering what each client needs, following up on time, knowing who came in today, and showing the board what the program accomplished.

Never pitch Surfdesk as a Clarity replacement for HUD-funded agencies. You'll lose, and you'd be wrong. Pitch it as the tool that makes the day work, next to the system they're required to use.

2. The problems Surfdesk solves (lead with these, not features)

Ask a program director these questions. Every "yes" is a reason to buy.

Ask them	The pain	What Surfdesk does about it
"Where do your case managers keep their follow-ups?"	Sticky notes, notebooks, Outlook, memory. Things slip.	One sentence ("call Ana Friday at 3") becomes a reminder linked to the client. Notes that mention a to-do suggest the task automatically.
"When a case manager leaves, what happens to what they knew?"	Knowledge walks out the door.	Every note, task and check-in lives on the client's timeline, and client records stay with the agency.
"How does your front desk sign people in?"	Paper sheets, typed up later (or never).	Tablet **kiosk**: clients type their name and reason, and it lands in the system instantly.
"How do partners send you referrals?"	Phone calls, emails, lost voicemails.	A public **referral link** with appointment booking and a "might already be a client" check.
"How long does your monthly funder or board report take?"	Days of pulling spreadsheets together.	The **Impact** report: people served (each counted once), new vs returning, demographics and busiest times, exported to PDF/Excel in a click.

Ask them	The pain	What Surfdesk does about it
"Can managers see who's falling behind?"	Not without asking everyone.	Team view: each worker's clients, open tasks and who needs follow-up.
"How long does it take to log a contact in your current system?"	Minutes of clicking through forms, so staff put it off.	Seconds. Type or say it.

The core value: fewer clients falling through the cracks, hours of admin saved every week, and reports without the scramble.

Where the hours come from:

- **Tracking:** no more rebuilding "who needs what" from notebooks, inboxes and memory. Every client's history and next step is in one place, shared by the whole team.
- **Reporting:** the numbers funders ask for (people served, new vs returning, demographics, busiest times, follow-through) are counted as staff work, so the monthly report is an export, not a project.
- **Turnover:** when someone leaves, an admin hands all of their clients, with every note, task and check-in, to another staff member in one step, and the person who left loses access right away. Nothing is lost and nobody starts from scratch.

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3. Who to pitch, and who to skip

Best fits (go after these first)

1. **Small and mid nonprofits with no HUD/HMIS requirement:** food pantries, youth programs, re-entry, workforce, community centers, faith-based outreach. Surfdesk can be their *whole* system.
2. **HUD-funded agencies whose staff hate their HMIS for daily work.** Surfdesk sits alongside it. Sell to the program manager, not IT.
3. **Programs inside larger agencies** (one team of 3–10 people) that want to try something without a big procurement process. Start there and expand.

Skip or slow down

- Anyone who needs Surfdesk to *produce HUD reports or replace their HMIS*. Be honest and move on.
- Medical or clinical programs that need to store health records under HIPAA (see section 5).
- Large agencies that require security questionnaires, contracts and procurement before a trial. Possible later, but slow to close right now.

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4. Objections, and what to say

"We already have Clarity."

> "Great, keep it. Clarity is how you report to HUD; nothing changes there. Surfdesk is for the day-to-day: follow-ups, reminders, the front desk, referrals. It's the part your staff are doing on sticky notes and spreadsheets right now."

"Our CoC decides what software we use."

> "Your CoC decides your HMIS, the system for HUD data. They don't decide how your case managers track their to-dos or how your front desk signs people in. Surfdesk replaces the spreadsheets and notebooks, not the HMIS."

"Staff won't enter things twice."

> "Most of what goes into Surfdesk never goes into the HMIS anyway: reminders, quick notes, who to call back. It takes one sentence, or they can just say it out loud. If it saves them chasing things later, they'll use it. Try it with one team for two weeks and see." *(Be honest: the required HUD fields still go into the HMIS. Surfdesk doesn't sync with Clarity yet.)*

"Does it do HUD reports (APR, CAPER, PIT)?"

> "No, and it's not trying to. That's what your HMIS is for. Surfdesk's Impact report is for everyone else who asks how you're doing: your board, private funders, foundations and city partners."

"Is client data safe?"

> "It's encrypted, and every account is walled off at the database level, so one organization can never see another's data. There's two-step sign-in, automatic sign-out on shared computers, and supervisors only see what their role allows. We never sell data or use it for ads, and you can export or delete everything any time."

"What about HIPAA?"

> "Surfdesk isn't built to hold medical records, so we don't sign HIPAA agreements yet. For case notes, follow-ups and check-ins that aren't health records, you're fine. Clinical details should stay in your clinical system." *(Don't claim HIPAA compliance. Our privacy policy says not to enter protected health information without a written agreement.)*

"You're a small company. What if you disappear?"

> "Your data is never locked in. You can export everything to Excel, CSV or a full backup any time, and billing is month to month with no contract. It runs on the same infrastructure big companies use. And you get the founder on support, not a ticket queue."

"We have no budget."

> "A team of five is $95 a month. If it saves each case manager 30 minutes a week, that's 10 staff hours a month, about $250 at $25 an hour. It pays for itself in the first month. And the first 14 days are free; nothing is charged until the trial ends." *(This is **ROI**, return on investment: what they get back for what they spend. Use their own hourly rate if you know it.)*

"We just use Excel and Google Calendar. It's fine."

> "It works until someone's out sick and nobody knows who to call back. Surfdesk takes your existing Excel client list in one upload, and your Google Calendar shows up inside it. You keep what works and lose the chasing."

"Our staff aren't tech-savvy."

> "If they can send a text, they can use this. They type a sentence or tap the mic and talk. It installs on any phone like an app."

"When a case manager leaves, do they take their clients?"

> "No. Client records belong to the agency. When someone leaves, an admin picks who takes over their clients, and everything (notes, tasks, check-ins) moves over in one step. The person who left loses access immediately. An admin can also move a single client to another worker any time. Each person's *personal* tasks and notes stay private to them, so staff aren't worried about being watched."

"Can we trust the report numbers?"

> "Each person is counted once per period, by the day they actually came in, in your organization's time zone, so every admin sees the same numbers. Clients you import count as new only if their intake date falls in that period, so uploading your existing list doesn't inflate your numbers. Past reports never change after the fact: only admins can delete agency clients, and a deleted client still counts in the months they were served. The PDF and Excel exports show the same figures as the screen."

"Supervisors want visibility, but staff want privacy."

> "That's built in. In Surfdesk, supervisors are **Managers**: they see every client and every member's work, read-only. Admins manage staff. Personal tasks and lists are never visible to anyone else."

"How long does setup take?"

> "Minutes. Create the organization, invite staff by email, and upload your client list from Excel. The kiosk and referral link are a couple of clicks each."

"Is there a phone app?"

> "It installs from the browser onto any phone or tablet with its own icon, full screen, no app store needed. Store versions are coming."

"Can it text clients or send reminders?"

> "Reminders show in the app today. Push notifications and text reminders are built and are being switched on." *(Don't promise a date.)*

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5. Honest limits (never get caught overpromising)

Surfdesk does not (yet)	What to say instead
Produce HUD reports or act as an HMIS	"Keep your HMIS for HUD. We're the daily tool."
Sync with Clarity or export in HMIS format	"Not yet. It's on our list for organizations."
Coordinated entry (shared assessments, prioritization, bed reservations)	"That stays in your HMIS."
Sign HIPAA agreements or store medical records	"Keep clinical records in your clinical system."
Send push or text reminders (built, not switched on)	"In-app reminders today; push and text are coming."
Have App Store / Google Play listings	"Installs from the browser on any phone today."
Sign in with Google or Apple	"Email and password with optional two-step sign-in."

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6. How to close

1. **Start small.** One program, 3–10 staff, on the 14-day free team trial ($0 today; a card is required, one trial per card).
2. **Set it up with them in the first meeting:** create the organization, invite staff, upload their Excel client list, and turn on the kiosk or referral link if they use one. Aim to leave with it already working.
3. **Agree on what success looks like in 14 days.** For example:
   - Every client contact gets logged the same day.
   - No overdue follow-ups at the end of each week.
   - The monthly board/funder report takes minutes, not days.
4. **Check in at day 5 and day 12.** Show the director the Team view and the Impact report with their own numbers. That's the moment they decide.

5. **Eager buyers:** if they already know they want it, point them to **"Skip the trial: 30% off your first month"** on the Billing page. They start paying today, and you skip the 14-day wait.
6. **Convert:** they choose the number of seats in Billing. Expand to the next program once the first one sticks.

Your closing line:

> "Keep everything you're required to use. Give your team two weeks with Surfdesk for the day-to-day work, and if your follow-ups and reports aren't easier, you've lost nothing."